

LEADERSHIP STUDIES

Overview

The Leadership Studies Program provides a versatile foundation of coursework and experiences for undergraduate students in any major who want to lead, follow, and collaborate effectively in professional and community settings. Through a 21-credit Certificate program and a 15-credit Minor, students explore leadership as a dynamic relational process shaped by context, environment, and multiple perspectives — and gain practical skills in self-awareness, teamwork, and strategic communication.

The program is designed to help students develop insight into how people influence, motivate, and guide others in organizations, communities, and systems. Coursework and experiences intentionally cultivate career readiness by developing every core competency that employers value in college graduates — including critical thinking, communication, collaboration, leadership, professionalism, and adaptability — ensuring that students are prepared to succeed and make a meaningful impact in their chosen fields.

Graduates of the program will be prepared to engage thoughtfully and adaptively, demonstrating the awareness, resilience, and ethical grounding necessary to lead and follow with purpose.

Learning Outcomes

Upon completion of the certificate or minor in Leadership Studies, students will be able to:

- Recognize leadership as an evolving set of skills, knowledge, attitudes, and behaviors that can be developed through reflection and practice.
- Examine established and emergent leadership theories and connect them to real-world situations across contexts.
- Communicate leadership ideas and decisions effectively, using written, oral, and digital media to engage multiple perspectives.
- Apply leadership decision-making, teamwork, and relational dynamics across organizations and environments — demonstrating adaptability and purpose.
- Build and present a professional leadership portfolio or capstone project that clearly articulates their leadership identity, growth, and readiness for action in varied settings.

Leadership Studies Minor

The minor in leadership studies requires the completion of 15 credit hours through three 3-credit-hour required courses in leadership and organizational theory, and an additional 6 credit hours earned from approved leadership electives. At least 9 credits must be at the 2000-level or above, of which at least 6 credits are courses numbered 3000 or above.

A cumulative grade point average of at least 2.0 is required in courses taken for the Leadership Studies minor.

The Leadership Studies Undergraduate Minor is an LAS Minor. In addition to University policies governing minors (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/academics/#degreeplanningtext>), LAS minors require at least 6 credits in courses numbered 3000 and above, with a grade of C or higher.

Core Courses: 9 required credits

LDST 3010	Leadership Theory	3
LDST 3220	Leadership Practice	3
LDST 2910A	Leading Change: General	3
	or MGMT 3720 Ethical and Responsible Management	
	or WISE 2010 Women in STEM Leading Change	

Leadership Electives: Choose 6 credits from the following:

AESHM 2110	Leadership Experiences and Development (LEAD)	3
AESHM 4210	Developing Global Leadership: Maximizing Human Potential	3
AGEDS 3150	Personal, Professional, and Entrepreneurial Leadership in Agriculture	3
COMST 2180	Communication and Conflict Management	3
COMST 3130	Leadership Communication Theories	3
ENGR 1500	Foundations of Leadership Development and Learning	1
ENGR 2500	Leadership in Engineering Teams	1
ENGR 3500	Dean's Leadership Seminar	1
LDST 1220	Leading with Purpose	1
LDST 2700	Campus Leadership Development	3
LDST 2910B	Leading Change: U.S. Diversity	4
LDST 2910C	Leading Change: International Perspectives	4
LDST 2930	Special Projects	3
LDST/WGS 3330	Women, Gender, and Leadership	3
LDST 3700	Special Topics	1-3
LDST 4220	Leadership Capstone Seminar: Theory to Practice	3
ME 4120	Ethical Responsibilities of a Practicing Engineer	3
MGMT 3720	Ethical and Responsible Management	3
MGMT 4220	Negotiation and Conflict Resolution	3
MGMT 4720	Building Inclusive Work Cultures	3
PHIL 2350	Ethical Issues in a Diverse Society	3
SPCM 3120	Business and Professional Speaking	3

Leadership Studies Certificate

The certificate in leadership studies requires the completion of 21 credit hours including the 9-credit leadership studies core. The remaining

12 credit hours are earned from approved electives including 3 hours in communication, 6 hours in leadership, and 3 hours of a capstone experience through a course, internship or study abroad. The capstone course should focus on the scholarship of leadership in the student's field of study, whereas an internship or a study abroad should provide a leadership-in-practice experience.

The Leadership Studies Certificate is an LAS Certificate and must meet University-wide policies for undergraduate certificates (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/academics/#degreeplanningtext>). A cumulative grade point average of at least 2.0 is required in courses taken for the Leadership Studies certificate.

Core Courses:

9 credits of required core courses

LDST 3010	Leadership Theory	3
LDST 3220	Leadership Practice	3
LDST 2910A	Leading Change: General	3
	or MGMT 3720 Ethical and Responsible Management	
	or WISE 2010 Women in STEM Leading Change	

Communication Electives:

Choose 3 credits from the following:

COMST 2140	Professional Communication	3
COMST 3100	Intercultural Communication	3
COMST 3140	Organizational Communication	3
ENGL 3020	Business Communication	3
SPCM 2120	Fundamentals of Public Speaking	3
SPCM 3120	Business and Professional Speaking	3
SPCM/WGS 3230	Gender and Communication	3

Leadership Electives:

Choose 6 credits from the following:

AESHM 2110	Leadership Experiences and Development (LEAD)	3
AESHM 2220	Creativity on Demand	3
AESHM 2870	Principles of Management in Human Sciences	3
AESHM 4210	Developing Global Leadership: Maximizing Human Potential	3
AESHM 4740	Entrepreneurship in Human Sciences	3
AGEDS 3150	Personal, Professional, and Entrepreneurial Leadership in Agriculture	3
CE 3060	Project Management for Civil and Environmental Engineers	3
COMST 2180	Communication and Conflict Management	3
COMST 3130	Leadership Communication Theories	3

COMST 3170	Small Group Communication	3
CRP 4290	Planning in Developing Countries	3
CRP 4320	Urban Planning Studio	6
CRP 4350	Planning in Small Towns	3
CRP 4920	Planning Law, Administration and Implementation	3
CONE 3800	Engineering Law	3
ENGR 1500	Foundations of Leadership Development and Learning	1
ENGR 2500	Leadership in Engineering Teams	1
ENGR 3500	Dean's Leadership Seminar	1
HDFS 3950	Children, Families, and Public Policy	3
LAS 1510	Dean's Leadership Seminar I	1
LDST 1220	Leading with Purpose	1
LDST 2700	Campus Leadership Development	3
LDST 2900	Independent Study	1-3
LDST 2910A	Leading Change: General	4
LDST 2910B	Leading Change: U.S. Diversity	4
LDST 2910C	Leading Change: International Perspectives	4
LDST 2930	Special Projects	1-3
LDST/WGS 3330	Women, Gender, and Leadership	3
LDST 3700	Special Topics	1-3
LDST 4220	Leadership Capstone Seminar: Theory to Practice	3
LDST 4900	Independent Study	1-3
ME 4120	Ethical Responsibilities of a Practicing Engineer	3
MGMT 3720	Ethical and Responsible Management	3
MGMT 4220	Negotiation and Conflict Resolution	3
MGMT 4720	Building Inclusive Work Cultures	3
NS 4120	Leadership and Ethics	3
PHIL 2350	Ethical Issues in a Diverse Society	3
POLS 3100	State and Local Government	3
POLS 2710	Public Organizations and Leadership	3
POLS/WGS 3850	Women in Politics	3
POLS 4750	Management in the Public Sector	3
POLS 4870	Cyberpolitics	3
SOC 3100	Community	3
SOC/POLS 3340	Politics and Society	3
SPCM 1100	Listening	3
SPCM/POLS 4170	Campaign Rhetoric	3
UST 3150	Cyclone Aide Leaders Seminar	2
WGS 3010	International Perspectives on Women and Gender	3

Capstone Courses:

Choose 3 credits of the following:

LDST 4220	Leadership Capstone Seminar: Theory to Practice	3
LDST 4900	Independent Study (Must include a leadership focus and be pre-approved by the leadership studies faculty.)	1-3

Study abroad: Must include a leadership focus and be pre-approved by the leadership studies faculty.

Other capstones may be approved with leadership studies faculty permission if they include a significant leadership component (e.g., COMST 4040 or AESHM 4210 with a leadership-based project). Students wishing to take a capstone course not listed here must receive approval prior to registering for the course and must demonstrate in writing how the course includes a significant leadership component.